

THE GREAT AMERICAN BICYCLE BOOM

"My husband, my girls, and even some of the neighbors, I guess, think I'm some kind of kook," confessed a thirty-two-year-old housewife in 1966. Her quirk? Riding a bicycle for exercise. "You should hear the catcalls and hoots I get," she wrote to the advice columnist Molly Mayfield. "My husband is disgusted." The housewife begged Mayfield for a reality check: "If you tell me I'm a crazy nut, I'll stay off that bike."

Three months earlier, Mayfield had fielded a similar question from the peanut gallery: a horrified fifteen-year-old girl had discovered her father on his back in the living room, churning his legs in the air as if riding a bicycle upside down. "Imagine an old man of 42 doing gym exercises like a teen-ager," she wrote. "If one of my girlfriends saw him like that, I'd be laughed out of the school."

Mayfield tartly stuck up for both exercisers, but their weirdness was real. The 1890s bicycle craze had proved that physical activity led to better health, but that lesson had been largely forgotten by the 1950s. Postwar prosperity and an increasingly car-centric lifestyle had made for a population that was plumper and more sedentary than their grandparents.

There were some outliers, of course. Fitness evangelists like the TV bodybuilder Jack LaLanne found a following—his show premiered in 1953 and ran for decades—but the conventional wisdom held that vigorous exercise was bad for adults. Just like Victorian housewives hyperventilating in their tight corsets and heavy frocks, many middle-aged desk workers of the mid-twentieth century avoided any activity that might make them pant or sweat. And while most doctors recognized the value of sports for children's developing bodies, a great many warned that adults who tried the same exploits would wear their hearts out prematurely. "After [age] 25 or 30, competitive exertion is superfluous—and hurtful," wrote the internist and author Peter J. Steincrohn. A middle-aged fat man who works out at a gym is "a victim of slow suicide," he cautioned. "Exercise is a joke."

Ridiculous as cycling seemed for many adults in the mid-1960s, it seemed even more ridiculous for teenagers. "In high school, it just wasn't done," recalled one young man a few years later. "We wouldn't be caught dead riding a bike in those days." "I walked two miles each way to high school to avoid the embarrassment of being seen on a bike," recalled another man of his midsixties adolescence. "We had bike racks at school without a single bike parked on them." These were teens who had cycled as children; in fact, their childhoods coincided with a national surge in bicycle sales. But at around age twelve or thirteen—years before they were eligible to drive—they had put their bikes away. Cycling was considered kid stuff, even if the standard adult bike was a beast no child could lift: the full-size 1959 Schwinn Phantom "deluxe spring fork balloon model," for example, had a shipping weight of more than sixty-two pounds.

Still, bit by bit, an army of bike nerds was mustering, spurred by economics, technology, medical science, and ecology. By 1972, that army would conquer the country and, for a few brief

years, make the bicycle as cool as that sophisticated new sensation, the video game.

The trend started with postwar economics. In 1948, to help boost a British economy still struggling after World War II, the United States slashed the tariff on British lightweight bicycles from 30 percent to 15 percent or lower. The following year, to lower the price of its exports relative to those of other countries, Great Britain devalued the pound, which dropped the average wholesale price of an imported British bike in the United States from \$45 to less than \$37, a considerable drop in those years. The Brits also ramped up their production of bicycles for export. The result was a steady supply of affordable multigeared imports in American shops. Many of these cycles placed riders in the bent-over “down” posture of the racer, rather than the prim, upright posture Americans had by then become accustomed to. The imports were also among the first on the US market to feature derailleur gears, which allowed the rider to shift the chain between sprockets of different sizes in order to make riding faster (on flats and downhills) or easier (on uphill). Derailleurs had been in wide use in Europe since the 1930s, but in the United States they had been considered too complicated for children’s use and not smooth enough for track racers, who preferred single-speed bikes.

Adult-size bikes still made up just a sliver of the US market, but increasingly, the ones that were selling were imported. As these high-tech lightweights found buyers, including military veterans who had ridden similar cycles in England during the war, American makers responded by developing midweight (fifty-pound), three-speed models—not as sprightly as the imports, but not as expensive either. By 1960, US companies were producing their own European-style eight- and ten-speed bikes, notably the Schwinn Varsity, which at forty pounds was “lightweight” compared to balloon-tired American monsters, even if

not to Raleighs and other ten-speed imports, which weighed as little as twenty-two pounds.

If your only frame of reference was a one-speed balloon-tired bike, or even a midweight three-speed, then riding a ten-speed could be a revelation. First-time users reported that “the bike had a light, springy, alive feeling, not an inert heaviness,” according to *Sunset*. As one rider told the magazine in 1965, “It’s like a constant tail wind. Once you get that feeling, you never want to change.” According to the *Los Angeles Times*, the difference between a three-speed and a ten-speed was “the difference between driving a tank and a sports car.” The new technology began to make adult biking seem more worth the effort. As one 1964 ad for a Huffy brand ten-speed argued, “This Huffy is one reason you see more adults on bicycles today. . . . Your [old balloon-tire] bike was hard to pedal; this one skims over the ground.”

That kind of lightness echoed the descriptions of pneumatic safety bicycles when they were first introduced. And, like an old safety, the new ten-speeds gave riders a refreshing sense of freedom. “So many of us have a Kafkaesque feeling that we have no power over anything in modern society,” said the Chicago public relations man Eugene A. Sloane in 1970. “Bicycling offers a new feeling of independence.” (Sloane was the author of *The Complete Book of Bicycling*, published that year.) Comparisons of cycling to flying also began to reappear. In 1974, an ad for the ten-speed AMF Roadmaster depicted the bike ascending a tightrope carried aloft by a gigantic blue butterfly. The ad’s headline read, “Flying Machine.”

In summery locales like Florida and Southern California, grown-ups began taking ten-speeds on day trips and multiday touring vacations. Unlike the “dead weight” of a balloon-tired bike, these new models “put joy in an adult journey,” *Life* magazine explained. One young Southern California couple who typ-

ified the trend shipped their bikes five hundred miles north to San Francisco, flew up to meet them, and spent two weeks pedaling home along Highway 1. The pace gave them a new perspective on travel, they told a reporter. While a high-wheel cyclist of the 1880s might have exulted in the unprecedented speed of the overland jaunt, his 1960s counterparts exulted in the trip's leisurely pace. "You get a chance to notice little things—flowers, birds, trees," said the wife, identified as Mrs. William Rogan. "We talked to beatniks in Big Sur, to truck drivers in restaurants. It's a different world." In 1960, the *New York Times* noted the unexpected upswing in pedal-powered touring: "In this age of jet planes and tail fins, the bicycle would seem to stand about as much chance of survival as the sedan chair or the one-horse shay, but, strangely enough, the evidence is mounting that bike-riding is a growing outdoor sport." And bicycle ads started to target this full-grown, outdoorsy demographic. "Discover the call of far away places . . . romantic settings . . . and the total relaxation of the open road," urged a 1968 Schwinn ad (ellipses and all). "It's been there all along . . . just a short ride away on a new Schwinn bike!"

Plentiful imports and better gearing didn't fully explain the burgeoning bike revival, though. A changing attitude toward adult exercise also played a part. Prominent physicians—including, notably, the Harvard cardiologist Paul Dudley White—had been studying the effects of exercise on heart health. Their findings suggested that fitness buffs like LaLanne might have had the right idea. More doctors started encouraging older adults to stay active. "I'd like to put everybody on bicycles," White frequently proclaimed. "That's a good way of preventing heart disease."

White's pro-exercise position—and the bicycle itself—got a PR boost in 1955, when then-president Dwight D. Eisenhower had a serious heart attack. White flew to the president's bedside

as a consultant and became the spokesman for his medical care team. Rather than the traditional postcoronary treatment of prolonged bed rest, White recommended exercise such as cycling, which he himself had done regularly since he was a Harvard freshman in 1904. "Some believe that vigorous exercise not only helps the general health but also helps a healthy person to delay the onset of serious coronary atherosclerosis," White wrote shortly after Eisenhower's heart attack. "We have inadequate information about this, altho[ugh] many of us, including President Eisenhower, have found that exercise makes them feel better." A few American adults took the hint and started cycling for heart health, though drivers didn't always appreciate the new obstacles in their midst. In Baltimore in 1956, cat-calls from drivers to health-minded adult cyclists included, "What's the matter? Too cheap to buy a car?" and "Now ain't you ashamed—at your age."

The medical case for exercise gained even more credibility in the 1960s after a University of Oregon track coach introduced a new practice called "jogging" and advocated it for "anyone—six to 106—male or female." As the historian Alan Latham has ably documented, Coach Bill Bowerman largely created the phenomenon of nonathletes trotting around for fitness in the United States. Bowerman had been converted to the health benefits of noncompetitive running during a 1962 trip to New Zealand, and he wanted to spread the word. He and several medical researchers launched a series of studies, and they found that sedentary men over thirty who took up jogging could lower their blood pressure and lose weight without dieting. The group published their findings in 1967 in the *Journal of the American Medical Association* as well as in a guidebook that sold more than one million copies. By the following year, tens of thousands of formerly inactive adults had taken up the habit. Given the potential gains and low cost of the new regimen, the *Chicago Tribune* noted that

year, “probably the only disadvantage to jogging is the feeling of looking ridiculous.” (The wisdom of exercise for adults was still being debated, though. Speaking at a Washington, DC, Medical Society seminar on the topic in 1969, a skeptical Peter Steincrohn opined that “pushing 40 or 50 is exercise enough.”)

As the sight of adults exercising outdoors became more common, both jogging and cycling began to lose their stigma. Eventually, many Americans who had started out as joggers switched to cycling out of boredom or discomfort. “Jogging might be good for you, but you feel like you’re going to drop dead any minute,” an IRS auditor named Henry Bernard told the *Washington Post* in 1970. “So one day I took my son’s bike to work . . . I went through the park and I could smell the trees. . . . I’d been cooped up in the car for so long I forgot there was such a thing as honeysuckle.”

And besides being easier than jogging and more fun than driving—at least in fair weather, for short distances, and without heavy cargo—biking in traffic-congested cities was often significantly faster than taking a car or a bus. “It’s the swiftest way to get uptown,” the Broadway producer Morton Gottlieb told the *New York Times* in 1970. Gottlieb, then forty-nine, enjoyed racing the No. 5 bus up the Avenue of the Americas. “I haven’t lost yet,” he said with a grin. For a Washington, DC, bike commuter named “Lucky” Wentworth, cycling was the only private conveyance that made sense. “I think most people are starting to realize that cars in the city are, well, insane,” he told the *Washington Post* in 1971. Although bikers were still a tiny minority of commuters—no doubt less than 1 percent—they had become a noticeable presence on urban streets for the first time since munitions-factory workers rode their drab Victory bicycles in the 1940s.

After decades stuck in the schoolyard, the bicycle was reasserting its old usefulness for adults. As in the 1890s, grown-ups

recognized that cycling was a fun way to get around and stay fit. And in the 1960s, a new crisis gave the bicycle an additional role to play: as a symbolic would-be savior of the planet.

Since the 1950s, Americans had grown increasingly troubled by pollution of the nation's air and waterways. Books like Rachel Carson's 1962 antipesticide opus *Silent Spring* and events like a disastrous 1969 oil spill off the coast of Santa Barbara drew attention to the toxic potential of poorly regulated industries. There were no federal emission standards before 1965, so cars spewed smoke. This mixed with fog to create a thick smog that killed hundreds of asthma patients and elderly people in repeated "smog episodes" across the country. At a building dedication in Cincinnati in the mid-1960s, the US surgeon general, Luther L. Terry, summed up the situation. "There is now nearly six times as much pollution in our rivers, streams, and lakes as 60 years ago, and the amount is still increasing," he said. "We are in danger . . . of creating an incredible disharmony in nature which will ultimately degrade and enslave us." The warnings were dire, some histrionically so. One 1968 best-seller, *The Population Bomb*, warned of overpopulation that would lead to environmental devastation and global starvation within ten years.

Among a public already mobilized to demonstrate for—or against—civil rights, women's rights, and an end to the Vietnam War, cleaning up the environment became just one more cause to pursue. Activists pushed for legislation to curb pollution, organizing demonstrations that included the first Earth Day, on April 22, 1970. During that event, some twenty million Americans gathered at sites around the country to demand action, helping bring about federal environmental protection laws such as the Clean Air Act (1970), the Clean Water Act (1972), and the Endangered Species Act (1973).



Nancy Pearlman (wearing a gas mask to protest smog), Janice Jones, Debbie Melville, and Kathy Briggs were captured in 1971 by *Los Angeles Times* photographer Don Cormier. This image was provided by the UCLA Library under a Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International License.

As a nonpolluting vehicle, the newly un-ridiculous bike fit right in. For many, cycling became a political statement. “The alternative to sitting around and complaining about smog is biking when you can,” Mrs. James Mahan, a mother of three, told the *Los Angeles Times* in 1971. By cycling, “we’ve done something, however small, to communicate that we believe in what we feel.” Some political statements were small scale, such as the decision of twenty-something Nancy Pearlman to wear a gas mask during a 1971 bicycle ride in Los Angeles. Others were grander, such as a 1,500-person “Pollution Solution” ride that year, organized by the same Nancy Pearlman, founder of Concerned Bicycle Riders for the Environment. Activists like these saw the bike as more than a form of zero-emission trans-

portation. They saw it as a chariot to enlightenment. In its 1971 manifesto, the Santa Barbara group Friends for Bikecology urged readers to take responsibility for the state of the planet by cycling rather than driving: "If we desire to change the world we live in, let's find the magnet which draws man to the land, in contact with its forces—the bicycle."

So in the same ten-year span, ten-speed bikes became more widely available, exercise for adults became more acceptable, and environmentalism entered the mainstream. What all this meant for the bicycle was a boom that started in the early 1960s and just kept building. Between 1960 and 1970, the number of bikes in use in the United States doubled, as did per capita ridership. Then in 1971, bike sales exploded, shocking retailers and manufacturers alike. At the sixty-four J. C. Penney stores in Southern California, bicycle shipments increased fivefold between July 1970 and July 1971. "No one could have predicted it," said the president of the Murray Ohio Manufacturing Company, which built store-brand bicycles for J. C. Penney and Sears. "We're not clairvoyant."

Producers couldn't keep up with orders. In 1971, Schwinn sold out its entire annual production run of 1,225,000 bikes by the third week of May. "If we could have increased our production by 50 percent or even 100 percent, we couldn't have met the demand," a Schwinn marketing executive said that summer. European and Japanese importers tried to fill the gap, but it was too vast. American bike stores became mob scenes, and by that fall ten-speeds were nowhere to be bought. A *Washington Post* reporter named B. D. Colen hunted for weeks before locating a shop owner who was expecting a shipment. Colen offered to pay for a bike in advance, sight unseen, but the merchant said no. "I've had 600 to 800 people calling asking for 10-speeds. I've had them offer me \$25 to \$30 over retail just to hold one. We just can't take any orders." The reporter eventually found a shop

that would take an order for a French Gitane cycle to be delivered five weeks later—"and if you think I'll tell you where," he wrote in the paper, "think again."

By 1972, there were eighty-five million cyclists in the country: one out of every two people between the ages of seven and sixty-nine, according to a federal report. (In 1896, the year that "everything was bicycle," the US population was two-thirds smaller than it would be in 1970, but the number of cyclists was more than *forty times* smaller.) Bicycles outsold cars in the United States in 1972, and the year after that, and the year after that. And for the first time since the days of the Victory bike, most cycles sold in the United States were full-size. In 1971, 86 percent of Schwinn's bike sales were to adults, a complete reversal from just four years earlier. One New York City bicycle dealer jokingly estimated that if his customer ratio in 1970 was three children for every three adults, in 1971 it was "four-and-a-half kids to 300 adults." The bicycle had become more than acceptable for adults to ride. Unthinkably, it had become cool. In September 1971, the *New Yorker* writer Calvin Trillin took part in a 200-person ride down Manhattan's Fifth Avenue to demand bike lanes on city streets. "Most people who looked up at us smiled," he noted. "At 23rd Street, a young man walked over to me while we were stopped at a red light and, looking very somber about it all, informed me that bicycling was groovy." (Manhattan didn't get its first on-street bicycle lanes until 1978.)

In October 1973, Arab oil-producing countries gave Americans yet another reason to cycle: they cut off petroleum exports to the United States. This embargo, which lasted six months, was intended to penalize America for its support of Israel in that year's Arab-Israeli war, and the result was a punishing energy crisis. American drivers waited hours in line at gas stations, only to find that the pumps had run dry. Gas prices quadrupled. The pedal-powered bike looked more practical than ever, as market-

ers were quick to note. “The USA energy shortage?” asked a 1974 bike ad. “Think of how much gas you’d save” using “good ol’ American leg power. . . . The Vista 10-speed Esquire . . . it’s a gas!”

Cycling was especially appealing for college students. On campuses, the mix of strong young bodies, short commutes, and light vehicle traffic yielded thick swarms of bikes. At Cal State Fullerton in 1971, 10 percent of students arrived by bicycle. Although the school bought five new racks that fall, bicycle parking was hard to come by. “Students chain their bikes to any tree or pole or railing they can find,” the *Los Angeles Times* reported. “Each lamp post on campus always has at least two bikes chained to it.” At the University of Illinois in Urbana-Champaign in 1973, cycle paths coursed with endless streams of traffic; pedestrians complained of waits as long as fifteen minutes to cross. By 1975, it seemed that every scholar had a bike. “Take a look at the average college campus,” wrote an essayist in the *Christian Science Monitor* that year. “Students cry poverty, but if any student is not able to satisfy his yearning for a 10-speed, it’s not noticeable.”

As it happened, though, that year marked the end of the 1970s bicycle fad. Sales fell 50 percent between 1974 and 1975, and by 1976, US manufacturers were starting to go bankrupt. “The ‘boom’ has turned into a ‘bust,’” the president of the Huffman Manufacturing Company sadly testified before the Senate Finance Committee. Part of what popped the bike bubble may have been the poor quality of many of the machines people were riding. Due to the frantic demand, many ten-speeds sold during the 1970s were cheaply made and frustratingly prone to breakdown, as the cycle historian Frank Berto argues. “Anything with a derailleur could be sold,” he writes in the book *The Dancing Chain*. “Some of these were truly horrid.” Many once-coveted ten-speeds ended up in a corner of the garage—or at the dump.

Then, too, the high demand had created an easy secondary market for stolen bicycles. By 1971, bike thievery had become “a thriving business” nationally, as the *Los Angeles Times* reported; in 1975, *Time* magazine called it “America’s fastest-growing crime.” Many adults no doubt stopped riding their ten-speeds because they got tired of replacing stolen bikes—or just got tired of worrying that they would be stranded if a thief made off with their wheels.

And this points up a bigger change that seems to have contributed to the passing of the second great bike boom: the rising reality of urban crime. Because cities are densely built, they ought to be especially well-suited to the utility cyclist. Work, school, and shops tend to be located close enough to home to ride to; streets are paved; traffic is calmed by frequent stop signs and signals. But after the race riots of the 1960s—which began with protests against police brutality in Harlem and Philadelphia in 1964 and continued through the angry nationwide response to the assassination of Martin Luther King Jr., in 1968—the American middle class increasingly abandoned the urban core. The 1973–1974 energy crisis had helped trigger an economic downturn that knocked municipal governments on their heels; in 1975, New York City turned to the federal government for a bailout to avoid defaulting on its municipal bonds. (The feds obliged, but only after President Gerald Ford demanded that city leaders raise revenues and cut spending, a stance immortalized in the *New York Daily News* headline “Ford to City: Drop Dead.”) The US crime rate doubled in the 1960s, and then nearly doubled again in the 1970s. Theft and assault became a fact of urban life.

Compared to cars, bicycles left riders more vulnerable to attack. On Easter 1974, for example, two young women were jumped by a gang of teenage boys with rubber tubes and clubs on a bike path in Washington, DC’s Rock Creek Park. When one

of the women went to the emergency room, an attendant there told her that they had been treating one injured cyclist a week due to assaults in the park. And during a 1980 transit strike in New York, office workers started commuting by bike across the Brooklyn Bridge—and criminals started lying in wait for them there. One night that July, four muggers attacked and robbed a cyclist and held him captive for two hours, during which time he watched them rob and beat another cyclist as well. “The situation there borders on barbarism,” the president of the Federation of New York Bicycle Clubs said.

On-street cycling was already dangerous in the United States because roads had been built or rebuilt with cars in mind. Side paths had vanished; bike lanes were few. And the ubiquitous curb cuts that ease sidewalk riding today were nowhere in sight back then: most of them were installed after the passage of the Americans with Disabilities Act of 1990. So cyclists already had to be wary of drivers. With crime on the increase, some bikers must have felt they ought to begin fearing pedestrians as well.

And the baby boom generation that had fueled the ten-speed fad was starting to settle down. Some who had gotten caught up in the exhilaration of the ten-speed craze as childless young adults had become the parents of young children, for whom the risk-reward calculus was often different. Increasingly, it seemed that the risk of cycling wasn’t worth the reward. Americans didn’t completely stop riding bikes after 1975, of course. But given the frightening trajectory of the American city—the bicycle’s natural habitat—maybe it was inevitable that the early-’70s mania wouldn’t last.

Still, by the end of the boom, the bike had decisively shed its just-for-kids image. And some of the Americans who kept riding after 1975 ended up changing its identity further. Soon, a machine that had gone from trendy to dorky and back again would become the ultimate expression of gonzo individualism.